

PROTESTANTS VERSUS Catholics

THE REFORMATION

The Reformation of the 16th century was a revolutionary challenge to Catholicism, which led to the establishment of Protestant churches across Europe. The German theologian Martin Luther ignited the Reformation in 1517 with his Ninety-five Theses, which disputed many Catholic teachings. Luther had been a monk, and in 1525 married Katharina von Bora, a former nun who had become interested in reformist thought. While Protestantism was open to priests marrying, it still held a narrow view of women, who were confined to domestic roles. Von Bora managed Luther's extensive household, and became the role model of the supportive wife. Other Protestant priests followed Luther's example and also began to marry and start families, marking a clear contrast to the celibate Catholic clergy.

Another influential former nun was Elisabeth Cruciger, a poet who wrote some of the earliest Protestant hymns.

However, the first known female Protestant writer

was a Bavarian noble, Argula von Grumbach, who published several pamphlets and letters that defended Luther and other reformers.

Catholic women also contributed to the Counter-Reformation—the intellectual response to Protestantism in the 16th century. Notable among them were Teresa of Avila, the Spanish religious reformer of the

Carmelite order, and Angela Merici, who founded the Ursulines, one of the oldest Catholic teaching orders, in Italy in 1535.

Leading the reformation

Events in Europe helped spark an English Reformation, in which women played a central role, among them Anne Boleyn. Henry VIII instigated the Church of England's 1534 split from Rome so that he could divorce his first wife and marry Boleyn. She was interested in Luther's reformist stance and,

due to her influence on the king and promotion of the vernacular Bible, Protestant thinkers gained prominence. Later, English queens also influenced religion. During Mary I's reign, hundreds of Protestants were burned for heresy, and these martyrs included over 50 women. When Mary died, her half-sister Elizabeth I came to the throne, overseeing a settlement that would permanently return England to the Protestant fold.

After the Reformation leader John Calvin settled in Geneva, Switzerland, the city became a center of reform that also offered refuge to Protestant thinkers. One of these was Marie Dentièrre, a former abbess who left her convent to escape persecution, and moved to Geneva in 1528 after marrying a minister.

Between 1580 and 1675, Protestant Saxony saw 30% more schools for girls

◀ Hail Mary

This rosary and prayer book belonged to Mary, Queen of Scots. As a Catholic, Mary was not trusted by Protestants in Scotland or England; eventually she was executed by Elizabeth I.

